

Climate Change and Health

Climate change is a major threat to human health. Rising temperatures, extreme weather events, changing rainfall patterns, and other climate-related changes can affect people directly and indirectly.

Extreme heat can cause heat exhaustion, heatstroke, cardiovascular problems, and other health complications. Older adults, children, outdoor workers, and people with existing health vulnerabilities can be particularly affected.

Climate change can also influence infectious diseases. Changes in temperature and rainfall can affect the distribution of mosquitoes and other disease vectors. This can increase the risk of diseases such as malaria and dengue in some regions.

Food and water security are also affected by climate change. Droughts, flooding, and changing agricultural conditions can reduce food availability and affect access to safe drinking water.

Climate change can also affect mental health. Extreme weather events, displacement, loss of homes, and disruption of communities can contribute to stress, anxiety, and other psychological difficulties.

Health systems need to prepare for climate-related risks. Climate-resilient health infrastructure, disease surveillance, emergency preparedness, and public-health planning can help communities respond to changing conditions.

Reducing greenhouse-gas emissions can provide health benefits. Cleaner energy and reduced air pollution can improve air quality while also helping to limit long-term climate change.

Important evidence gaps remain. These include differences in climate impacts between regions, long-term mental-health effects, the resilience of health systems, and the full economic consequences of climate-related health risks.